

CASE STUDY

Trade Me × Moana Pasifika

Evaluating a culturally complex sports sponsorship

Module	SSP5106 — Applied Sport Marketing Communications
University	Cardiff Metropolitan University
Skills shown	Partnership analysis · Brand congruence · Strategic recommendations · Risk assessment

The brief

Analyse and critically evaluate a proposed sponsorship between Trade Me — New Zealand's largest e-commerce marketplace — and Moana Pasifika, the Pacific Island rugby team competing in Super Rugby Pacific. The task was to assess whether the partnership made commercial and cultural sense, identify its risks, and make strategic recommendations.

The two brands

Trade Me is New Zealand's most prominent e-commerce platform, acquired by Apax Partners in 2019 for NZ\$2.56 billion. Its brand positioning centres on community and accessibility — the idea of helping Kiwis "create the life they want." It dominates in real estate, jobs, motors, and consumer marketplace listings.

Moana Pasifika is a professionally run Super Rugby team representing Pacific Island communities in New Zealand. The squad includes elite talent like Ardie Savea, 2023 World Rugby Player of the Year, and is coached by Tana Umaga. The club's identity is rooted in Pacific cultural values — mana, manaakitanga (hospitality), and whanaungatanga (kinship) — making it far more than a sports team to its fanbase.

My approach

I applied the Prendergast, Poon and West (2010) four-dimension congruence framework to evaluate the partnership across four lenses: functional, image, demographic, and cultural fit. This gave me a structured way to identify both the opportunities and the points of tension in the deal.

A sponsorship that looks good on paper can still fail if the cultural layer is handled carelessly. This partnership lives or dies on authenticity.

Congruence analysis

Here's how the partnership stacks up across each dimension:

Dimension	Strength	Key risk
Functional	Moderate	No direct product overlap — requires creative activation to justify the link
Image	Moderate–High	Shared community values, but risks inauthenticity if Trade Me doesn't follow through
Demographic	Moderate	Moderate audience overlap — needs localised Pasifika-language campaigns to close the gap
Cultural	Low–Moderate	Strongest risk area — Trade Me must co-design with Pasifika leaders, not around them

The functional gap is the most obvious — Trade Me is an e-commerce platform with no direct connection to rugby. But as I noted in the analysis, this doesn't automatically disqualify the deal. Nike's partnership with basketball (no functional link to footwear) succeeded because the activation strategy was creative enough to bridge the gap.

The cultural dimension is where I spent the most time, and where I believe the partnership carries the highest risk. Moana Pasifika's identity is built on Pacific cultural values that Trade Me, as a corporate technology platform, has no inherent connection to. The difference between a tokenistic badge-on-jersey and a genuine partnership comes down to whether Trade Me is willing to invest in community co-design — not just community optics.

What I found

The partnership is viable, but it's not a safe bet in its default form. The image congruence is genuinely there — both brands are associated with New Zealand identity and community connection — but that alignment is fragile. It becomes powerful with the right activation and completely counterproductive with the wrong one.

Three specific points of tension I identified:

- Authenticity risk: Trade Me's corporate, technology-first brand image sits in contrast to Moana's grassroots, culturally rooted identity. Without a clear strategy for bridging this, the partnership risks looking opportunistic — particularly to the Pasifika communities it's trying to reach.
- Demographic mismatch: Trade Me's broad urban user base overlaps only partially with Moana's fanbase. Closing this gap requires targeted, localised campaigns — including Pasifika-language content — not a one-size-fits-all approach.
- Cultural tokenism: The biggest failure mode. If Trade Me's Pasifika engagement is superficial — logos on kits, one activation per season — the backlash within Pacific communities could damage the brand more than the sponsorship ever helped it.

My recommendations

I proposed three activation strategies that would shift the partnership from transactional to genuinely valuable:

- Co-branded community investment: Trade Me funds Pasifika youth scholarships or sports clinics, co-designed with Moana's leadership rather than imposed by the sponsor. This mirrors the approach of Procter & Gamble's "Thank You, Moms" Olympic campaign — finding the human story that already exists within the partnership.
- Platform integration with purpose: Trade Me uses its marketplace to host Moana Pasifika official merchandise auctions and job listings in rugby communities. This creates a functional link where none previously existed, while driving real platform value.
- Cultural storytelling as a long-term play: Trade Me commissions content that genuinely platforms Pasifika perspectives — not brand campaigns featuring Pasifika people, but stories made by and with the community. Aligned with Trade Me's "customer aroha" brand value.

By committing to community co-creation rather than passive sponsorship, Trade Me could move from a transactional presence to a cultural ally — and build something genuinely rare: a partnership that deepens over time.

What this demonstrates

This project required me to think beyond the commercial mechanics of a sponsorship deal and interrogate its cultural logic. The skills I applied here — brand congruence analysis, audience mapping, risk identification, and strategic recommendation — are the core competencies I'd bring to any brand partnerships role.

It also sharpened my thinking on one of the most important questions in modern brand partnerships: when does shared values alignment become genuine, and when does it become performance? The answer, I found, lives in the activation — not the announcement.
